

Key Takeaway: Data-Driven Decision-Making is for Everyone

Data should be a key component in any communications plan. In the case of employment for people with disabilities, facts and statistics can help create powerful stories that could make the difference in securing support for legislation, or helping families decide that employment is right for their child.

From the number of people working for pay in an integrated job to the number served in facility-based non-work, data paints a picture of the status of employment in a state. State agencies should use data as a tool to move Employment First forward. Data may reflect progress or demonstrate challenges. Whatever the case, real numbers bring about a different type of conversation.

A representative from Minnesota, Mary Alice Mowry, described the way the state accesses, uses, and shares data to change conversations about employment from “why” to “how.”

- » Find out what kind of data will help your service system understand what is happening at the local or regional level to help improve their employment picture.
- » Research data systems in other states. Work with the SELN project team to identify colleagues in other states with data experiences to share. Reach out to SELN states to ask questions about their experiences using data to make decisions.
- » Review data systems available in your state, such as annual Medicaid eligibility data for wages, and evaluate whether each system can contribute to the state’s employment performance measurement activities or data-driven decision making.
- » Discover who controls relevant data, and recruit them to help gain access.
- » Make data available in graphs, charts, and text on a public website and in other accessible formats.
- » Provide regular reports to individuals and families, legislators, providers, staff, and other state agencies.
- » Analyze data at the individual, provider, and state levels.
- » Share data that is “good enough” versus perfect, to start building interest in usable information. Improve on the data once you have more support for its utility.
- » Tell the story of service delivery processes and outcomes at different levels to engage partners with varying points of view. These stories can educate partners on shared goals or outcomes.

SELN Hub members can navigate to the [Monthly Network Meeting groups page](#) for additional materials and discussion.

[Meeting Recording](#)



State Employment Leadership Network

The SELN is a place for states to connect, collaborate, and create cross-community support regarding pressing employment-related issues at state and federal levels for individuals with developmental disabilities.

The SELN was launched in 2006 as a joint program of the National Association of State Directors of Developmental Disabilities Services and the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston.



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